



(/)

< [Healthy Living \(/healthy-living\)](/healthy-living)

How Music Affects Your Mind, Mood and Body

December 2, 2022

By: [Megan Hoffer MM MT-BC](#), [Julie Avirett MM MT-BC](#), [Kelsey Bocharski Music Therapy Intern](#), [Joshua Da Costa Music Therapy Intern \(/blogs?authors=1658\)](#)

Categories: [Healthy Living \(/blogs?categories=1598\)](/blogs?categories=1598)



Do you find yourself tapping your foot while shopping? Or having all the feels while watching movies? No matter your race, ethnicity, age or gender, music is a common phenomenon that impacts everyone. Music can be a powerful tool with its ability to evoke strong emotional responses.

For example, music may lead to the release of dopamine, a feel-good neurotransmitter. Music is present in everyday life for most people. Here, we answer questions about how music can affect your brain and body.

Does Music Alter Moods and Relieve Stress?

The short answer is, yes! The Iso-principle (<https://doi.org/10.3390%2Fijerph182312486>) is a tool that matches a music listening experience to a current mood or emotion and then gradually shifts to music that represents a desired mood or emotion. If you want to listen to a song that you pair with anger or sadness, go ahead, but don't let it repeat too many times. Move on to music of the mood you desire. A music playlist that gradually moves from uncomfortable emotions to comfortable ones can be a healthy coping strategy and facilitate a positive mood change.

Active music-making positively affects neurotransmitters

(<https://my.clevelandclinic.org/health/articles/22513-neurotransmitters>), such as dopamine and serotonin, that influence mood. Dopamine influences focus, concentration, memory, sleep, mood and motivation. Likewise, serotonin impacts mood, sleep patterns, anxiety and pain. Active music-making can involve singing (<https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2015.01242>), playing an instrument or creating music electronically. Making music, specifically singing in a group, helps us feel connected to other people because of the production of the hormone oxytocin. Singing synchronizes breathing patterns to promote relaxation and reduce the hormone cortisol (<https://my.clevelandclinic.org/health/articles/22187-cortisol>), “the stress hormone.”

What Emotions Can Music Make You Feel?

Music can validate your current emotional state and influence your emotional destination. Again, the Iso-principle (<https://doi.org/10.3390%2Fijerph182312486>) can help us experience desired emotions. It works most effectively when we first find a song that matches our current feeling or mood. In music therapy, emotional regulation is frequently addressed. Music can elicit many, if not every, emotion. Knowing yourself and which music you pair with your emotions will improve self-regulation, or “feeling your feelings.”

Music and emotions are personal, cultural and associated with prior experiences. A song will not give everybody the same feeling. That is the beauty of the diversity in music and preference across diverse cultures and time periods. Research (<https://musicscience.net/cross-cultural-research-in-music-and-emotions/>) attributes this phenomenon to the messages our cultures and experiences have assigned to sounds before listening to a song.

While culture, memories and associations influence music and emotions, Berkley found an overlap across cultures and compiled an interactive music map based on people's responses with 13 emotional dimensions that people in China and the United States self-reported. You can check [Berkley's Interactive Music Map](https://www.ocf.berkeley.edu/~acowen/music.html) (<https://www.ocf.berkeley.edu/~acowen/music.html>) to find out what music makes you feel.

What Impact Does Music Have on Memory?

Music can help retain essential information despite memory loss. [Music memory](https://www.medicaldaily.com/scientists-confirm-memories-music-are-stored-different-part-brain-other-memories-242104) (<https://www.medicaldaily.com/scientists-confirm-memories-music-are-stored-different-part-brain-other-memories-242104>) is stored in the hippocampus, centrally located in the brain. Therefore, music memories are less likely to be negatively impacted by age or disease.

A [musical mnemonic](https://psychcentral.com/lib/memory-and-mnemonic-devices) (<https://psychcentral.com/lib/memory-and-mnemonic-devices>) device is a natural way to memorize and recall information. As children, we learn various academic and social concepts through songs. Similarly, these memory strategies are highly effective for adults. In fact, our brains automatically "[fill in the gaps](https://www.sciencedaily.com/releases/2005/04/050425202958.htm)" (<https://www.sciencedaily.com/releases/2005/04/050425202958.htm>) when a song suddenly stops.

Music therapists often incorporate these techniques with individuals to improve [memory retention](https://www.musictherapy.org/assets/1/7/FactSheet_Music_Therapy_and_Dementia_Care_or_developmental_learning) ([https://www.musictherapy.org/assets/1/7/FactSheet_Music_Therapy_and_Dementia_Care](https://www.musictherapy.org/assets/1/7/FactSheet_Music_Therapy_and_Dementia_Care_or_developmental_learning) or [developmental learning](https://www.musictherapy.org/assets/1/7/FactSheet_Music_Therapy_in_Special_Educatio) (https://www.musictherapy.org/assets/1/7/FactSheet_Music_Therapy_in_Special_Educatio goals. Music may activate memories and remind us of places, events or people. A familiar tune may elicit the emotions associated with those memories.

What Changes Does Music Have on Your Body?

Singing, playing instruments and even dancing can improve pain tolerance.

Researchers (<https://doi.org/10.1177/147470491201000403>) found that the physical movement used to create music provides a synchronized activity that significantly heightens the pain threshold. Music therapists are specifically trained clinicians that use music to address goals such as pain reduction

(https://www.musictherapy.org/assets/1/7/FactSheet_Music_Therapy_for_Pain_Management22update.pdf).

Because music is often an enjoyable activity, it can activate the release of endorphins, which creates a general feeling of well-being

(<https://my.clevelandclinic.org/health/body/23040-endorphins>). Music

therapy can successfully reduce post-operative pain, physical tension and influence heart and breathing rates. Fast music tends to increase pulse rate (<https://www.msjonline.org/index.php/ijrms/article/view/3734>) and blood pressure (<https://www.msjonline.org/index.php/ijrms/article/view/3734>). Slow music tends to decrease pulse rate and blood pressure, as well as breathing rate (<https://academic.oup.com/eurheartj/article/36/44/3043/2293535>).

How Does Music Affect Behavior?

Music can affect behavior by being a motivator, a timer for completing tasks or a mood enhancer. It may also impact our shopping habits.

Music is used in advertising to encourage brand recognition and create familiarity and positive association with various products.

Younger shoppers spend more time shopping when stores play instrumental music. Older shoppers spend more time shopping when there's music playing with lyrics. Baby boomers are likely to spend more money if classic

rock is playing in a store. Generations older than baby boomers are less likely to spend money if any music is playing.

If you are buying wine for the holidays, be aware that classical music (<https://www.acrwebsite.org/volumes/7467/volumes/v20/NA-20/>) may make you feel comfortable spending a little more money than those top 40 hits.

Store associates are another group of people who are highly influenced by music. People who work in retail (<https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1362/0267257022775891>) are more likely to engage with customers and be in a positive mood if they don't have to listen to the same music all day.

Why Do We Enjoy Holiday Music?

Holiday music is a vehicle that communicates sacred and secular stories of the season. People may enjoy holiday music because pivotal cultural and traditional events are often intertwined. Music fosters community, remembrance and celebrations.

Known as the Festival of Lights, (<https://www.proquest.com/docview/2616339132?pq-origsite=primo&accountid=4840>) Hanukkah is often associated with music and dancing. Starting at nightfall in Jerusalem, you are likely to hear people singing “Ma’oz Tzur (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4MRS5c7TbJw>).” In some families, singing songs while lighting the menorah candles is part of their valued traditions.

Christmas music can be associated with sacred or secular aspects of people's lives. People decorate houses combining lights with music (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GufRiBUZQPc&t=58s>). Families drive down streets playing Christmas music to create memories with their children. Caroling (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rU7BCH9i-oY>) in neighborhoods, or a similar tradition called Parrandas

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8VPOrUhU52c>) in Puerto Rico, includes singing to and with your communities using traditional music and instruments.

Falling directly after Christmas, Kwanzaa (<https://www.interexchange.org/articles/career-training-usa/history-principles-and-symbols-of-kwanzaa/>) is a non-religious and non-political holiday originated to bring Black Americans together. Music in Kwanza includes storytelling, dancing, drumming and singing (<https://www.songsforteaching.com/kwanzaasongs/>). Established in 1966, the holiday commemorates the African heritage of many Black Americans' history, culture and traditions.

While many people have fond memories and traditions with holiday music, it is important to be mindful. Some people have equally painful memories associated with holiday music or songs.

Music Therapy

Music Therapists (/services/music-therapy) are trained clinical professionals that use music to accomplish physical, emotional, cognitive and social goals. There are music therapists at Tallahassee Memorial Healthcare in a variety of clinical settings and through classes (/services/music-therapy/music-classes). You can also search the Certification Board for Music Therapists' website to find a music therapist (<https://my.cbmt.org/cbmtssa/f?p=CRTSSA:17800:15621132222825:::17800::>) in your area.

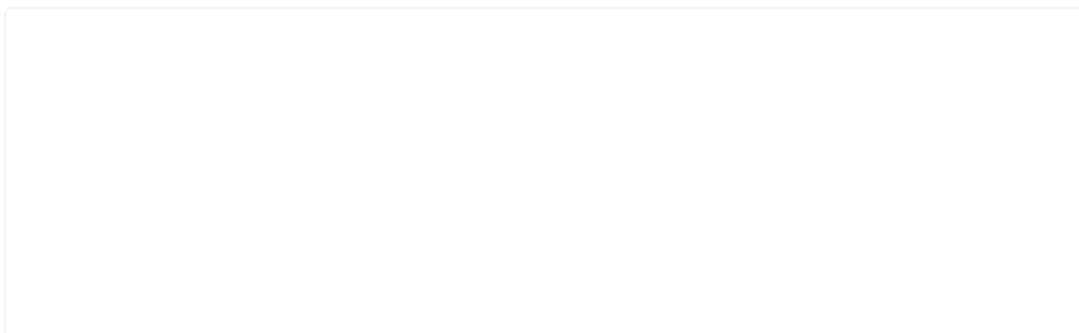
More articles
(/blogs?
authors=1658)



**Megan Hoffer MM MT-BC, Julie
Avirett MM MT-BC, Kelsey**

Bocharski Music Therapy Intern, Joshua Da Costa Music Therapy Intern

Related Posts







(850) 431-1155 (tel:+1850-431-1155)

1300 Miccosukee Road
Tallahassee, FL 32308

Get Directions(<https://maps.google.com/maps?daddr=1300+Miccosukee+Road,+Ta>)

Quick Start

[Find a Doctor \(/providers\)](#)

[Find a Location \(/locations\)](#)

[Login to MyChart \(/mychart\)](#)

[Give to TMH \(/tmh-foundation\)](#)

[Pay a Bill \(/patients-and-visitors/billing-and-financial-assistance-information\)](#)

[Classes & Events \(https://www.tmh.org/events-search\)](https://www.tmh.org/events-search)

[Volunteer \(/about-tmh/volunteer-opportunities\)](#)

[Contact Us \(/contact-us\)](#)

For Professionals

[Careers \(https://careers.tmh.org\)](https://careers.tmh.org)

[TMH Medical Staff \(/healthcare-professionals/tmh-medical-staff\)](#)

[TMH Colleagues \(/healthcare-professionals/tmh-colleagues\)](/healthcare-professionals/tmh-colleagues)

[Referring Physicians \(/healthcare-professionals/tmh-medical-staff/physician-referrals\)](/healthcare-professionals/tmh-medical-staff/physician-referrals)

[Lab Services \(/healthcare-professionals/lab-services\)](/healthcare-professionals/lab-services)

[Employment Verification \(/healthcare-professionals/tmh-colleagues/employment-verification\)](/healthcare-professionals/tmh-colleagues/employment-verification)

[EpicCare Link \(https://carelink.tmh.org\)](https://carelink.tmh.org)

Research and Education

[Clinical Trials \(/office-of-research/clinical-trials-tmh\)](/office-of-research/clinical-trials-tmh)

[Office of Research \(/office-of-research\)](/office-of-research)

[Residency Programs \(/residency-programs\)](/residency-programs)

More Resources

[Visiting a Patient \(/patients-and-visitors/visiting-a-patient-at-tallahassee-memorial\)](/patients-and-visitors/visiting-a-patient-at-tallahassee-memorial)

[News & Media \(/news\)](/news)

[Privacy Policy \(/privacy-policy\)](/privacy-policy)

[Price Transparency \(https://www.tmh.org/patients-and-visitors/billing-and-financial-assistance-information#standardRates\)](https://www.tmh.org/patients-and-visitors/billing-and-financial-assistance-information#standardRates)

[Notice of Privacy Practice \(https://www.tmh.org/sites/default/files/2023-11/fmi-tmh-npp.pdf\)](https://www.tmh.org/sites/default/files/2023-11/fmi-tmh-npp.pdf)

[Notice of Non-Discrimination \(/sites/default/files/2023-11/tmh-nondiscrimination-policy.pdf\)](/sites/default/files/2023-11/tmh-nondiscrimination-policy.pdf)



Sign Up for Our Newsletter(<https://tmh100.activehosted.com/f/11>)

**If you have a disability and experience difficulty
accessing this content, contact us
(https://tallahasseeememorial.formstack.com/forms/contact_fi
[field114461641=General%20Questions%20or%20Website%20Is](https://tallahasseeememorial.formstack.com/forms/contact_fi)**

Copyright 2025 Privacy Policy (/privacy-policy) | Terms of Use
Tallahassee (/sites/default/files/2023-11/fmi-tmh-npp.pdf) | Language
Memorial Assistance (/sites/default/files/2023-11/tmh-
HealthCare. nondiscrimination-policy.pdf)